

Pedro Magaña Sáenz

Agricultural and Applied Economics, University of Wisconsin-Madison

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Education

University of Wisconsin—Madison | Wisconsin, United States

Ph.D. in Agricultural and Applied Economics

May 2026 (expected)

University of Michigan—Ann Arbor | Michigan, United States

M.S. in Applied Economics

2019

M.A. in Public Policy

2019

Instituto Tecnológico Autónomo de México (ITAM) | Mexico City, Mexico

B.A. in Economics

2012

Fields of Interest

Development Economics; Agricultural Economics; Organizational Economics; Firms; Public Policy

Citizenship and U.S. work authorization

Mexican citizen with U.S. permanent residency

Working papers

Signed, Sealed, Delivered: Digital Receipts in the Ugandan Dairy Chain (Job Market Paper)

with David J. Henning

Using a randomized experiment with dairy cooperatives in western Uganda, we provide causal evidence that SMS-based digital receipts for daily milk deliveries improve accountability, product quality, and delivery frequency. In a context of weak monitoring and imperfect transaction information, these messages allow smallholder farmers to better observe the behavior of intermediaries in the supply chain. The intervention effects vary with the intensity of information frictions. Among farmers facing high information frictions (i.e., those relying on intermediaries to transport milk), the intervention increased the detection of discrepancies and encouraged switching away from dishonest intermediaries. Farmers in low-friction settings (those who deliver milk themselves) delivered more frequently; the likely mechanism is a behavioral nudge created by receiving messages both on days with deliveries and days without deliveries. We also find that the intervention increased milk quality for both self-deliverers and farmers using transporters. Overall, our results show that simple digital tools can reduce information asymmetries and strengthen accountability in smallholder supply chains.

Coverage: World Bank Development Impact Blog

Work in progress

Banking Amidst Conflict: How Violence Shapes Financial Inclusion in Mexico

with Xiaofei Wang

Digital Monitoring and Quality-Contingent Contracts: Aligning Incentives in the Ugandan Dairy Sector

with Taesoo Choi

Silent Transfers: Violence and Income Reporting in Mexico

From Prayer to Progress: Religious Festivals and Development in Mexico

Research Grants

PEDL CEPR – Exploratory Research Grant, £40,000 GBP	2026
Role: PI – with Taesoo Choi	
The Weiss Fund for Research in Development Economics – University of Chicago, \$15,000 USD	2025
Role: PI – with David J. Henning	
International Growth Centre (IGC) – Agri-SME Evidence Fund, £20,000 GBP	2024
Role: PI – with David J. Henning	
The Weiss Fund for Research in Development Economics – University of Chicago, \$15,000 USD	2023
Role: PI – with David J. Henning	
J-PAL/CEGA – Digital Agricultural Innovations and Services (DAISI) Initiative , \$71,000 USD	2023
Role: PI – with David J. Henning	
International Growth Centre (IGC) – Small Project Facility, £20,000 GBP	2022
Role: PI – with David J. Henning	
Total external funding raised as PI: \$206,000 USD	

Honors and Awards

AAE Conference Presentation Award (x2) – University of Wisconsin—Madison, \$1,600 USD	2025
AAEA Travel Grant – Agricultural & Applied Economics Association (AAEA)	2025
Thomsen Distinguished Graduate Dissertator Fellowship (nominated) – University of Wisconsin—Madison	2024
AAE Dissertator Research Award – University of Wisconsin—Madison, \$1,000 USD	2024
Barbara and Thomas Lyon Scholarship, \$4,000 USD, University of Wisconsin—Madison.	2023
UW-Madison Travel Grant, \$1,500 USD, University of Wisconsin—Madison	2022
Outstanding Teaching Assistant Award, University of Wisconsin—Madison	2021 – 2022
Rackham International Student Fellowship, \$10,000 USD, University of Michigan—Ann Arbor.	2019
Annenberg Internship, \$7,500 USD, University of Michigan—Ann Arbor	2017
Ford School Fellowship, \$2,500 USD, University of Michigan—Ann Arbor	2017

Research Experience

Research Assistant, University of Wisconsin Madison, Wisconsin	
Professors: Dr. Dustin Frye, Dr. Corbett Grainger, and Dr. Bradford Barham	2021 – Present
Research Assistant, University of Michigan Ann Arbor, Michigan	
Professors: Dr. Eduardo Montero and Dr. Zach Y. Brown	Spring 2020
Research Assistant, Center on Finance, Law and Policy, University of Michigan Ann Arbor, Michigan	
Professors: Michael Barr, J.D.; Dr. Antoinette Schoar, and Dr. Eldar Shafir	Fall 2019
Research Assistant, Northwestern University Chicago, Illinois	
Professors: Dr. Erika Deserranno and Dr. Gianmarco Leon-Ciliotta	Summer 2019
Research Associate, University of Michigan Ann Arbor, Michigan	
Economic Growth Institute	2018 – 2019
Research Assistant, University of Michigan Ann Arbor, Michigan	
Professors: Dr. Dean Yang; Dr. Xavier Giné, and Dr. Jessica Goldberg	2017 – 2018
Country Office Intern, Innovations for Poverty Action Lilongwe, Malawi	
Professors: Dr. Dean Yang; Dr. Xavier Giné, and Dr. Jessica Goldberg	Summer 2017
Research Coordinator, Instituto Tecnológico Autónomo de México (ITAM) Mexico City, Mexico	
Professors: Dr. Enrique Seira and Dr. Joyce Sadka	2011 – 2012

Professional Experience

Economic Analysis Coordinator, Ministry of Finance Mexico City, Mexico	2014 – 2016
Market Analyst, Laureate International Universities Mexico City, Mexico	2013 – 2014
Financial Analyst, Laureate International Universities Mexico City, Mexico	2012 – 2013
Parliamentary Advisor, Senate of Mexico Mexico City, Mexico	2010 – 2011

Teaching Experience

Teaching Assistant, University of Wisconsin | Madison, Wisconsin

AAE 474/ECON 474: Economic Problems of Developing Areas

AAE 350: World Hunger and Malnutrition

MATH 221: Calculus and Analytic Geometry II

Fall 2025

Spring 2022

Fall 2020

Teaching Assistant, University of Michigan | Ann Arbor, Michigan

PUBPOL 639: Quantitative Methods for Program Evaluation

POLSCI 369: International Economic Relations

PUBPOL 639: Quantitative Methods for Program Evaluation

POLSCI 490: Game Theory and Formal Models

Spring 2019

Fall 2018

Spring 2018

Fall 2017

Pre-Doctoral Publications

Magaña Sáenz, P.F. (2015). Behavioral Economics and Nudges Applied to Pawnshops. **Gaceta de Economía**, 34, 96-126. (Original in Spanish)

Talks

2026 PacDev 2026 (University of California, Davis), CSAE 2026 (University of Oxford), MEA 2026

2025 AFE 2025 (University of Chicago), World Bank–KDI School Development Impact Conference, AAEA/WAEA Joint Annual Meeting, 2025 WEFIDEV-RFS-CEPR Conference (LSE), Juli Plant Grainger Public Workshop, Applied Economics Workshop (University of Wisconsin)

2024 Development Workshop, Development Lab, Student Research Colloquium (University of Wisconsin)

2023 Development Workshop, Development Lab, Student Research Colloquium (University of Wisconsin)

2022 Development Lab, Student Research Colloquium (University of Wisconsin)

2021 Development Lab (University of Wisconsin)

Affiliations

Graduate Research Fellow, Institute for Research on Poverty, University of Wisconsin

2025 – 2026

Other Information

Languages: Spanish (Native), English (Fluent)

Skills: Stata (Advanced), L^AT_EX (Advanced), Microsoft Office (Advanced), R (Intermediate), Python (Intermediate)

References

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